United States Government Accountability Office

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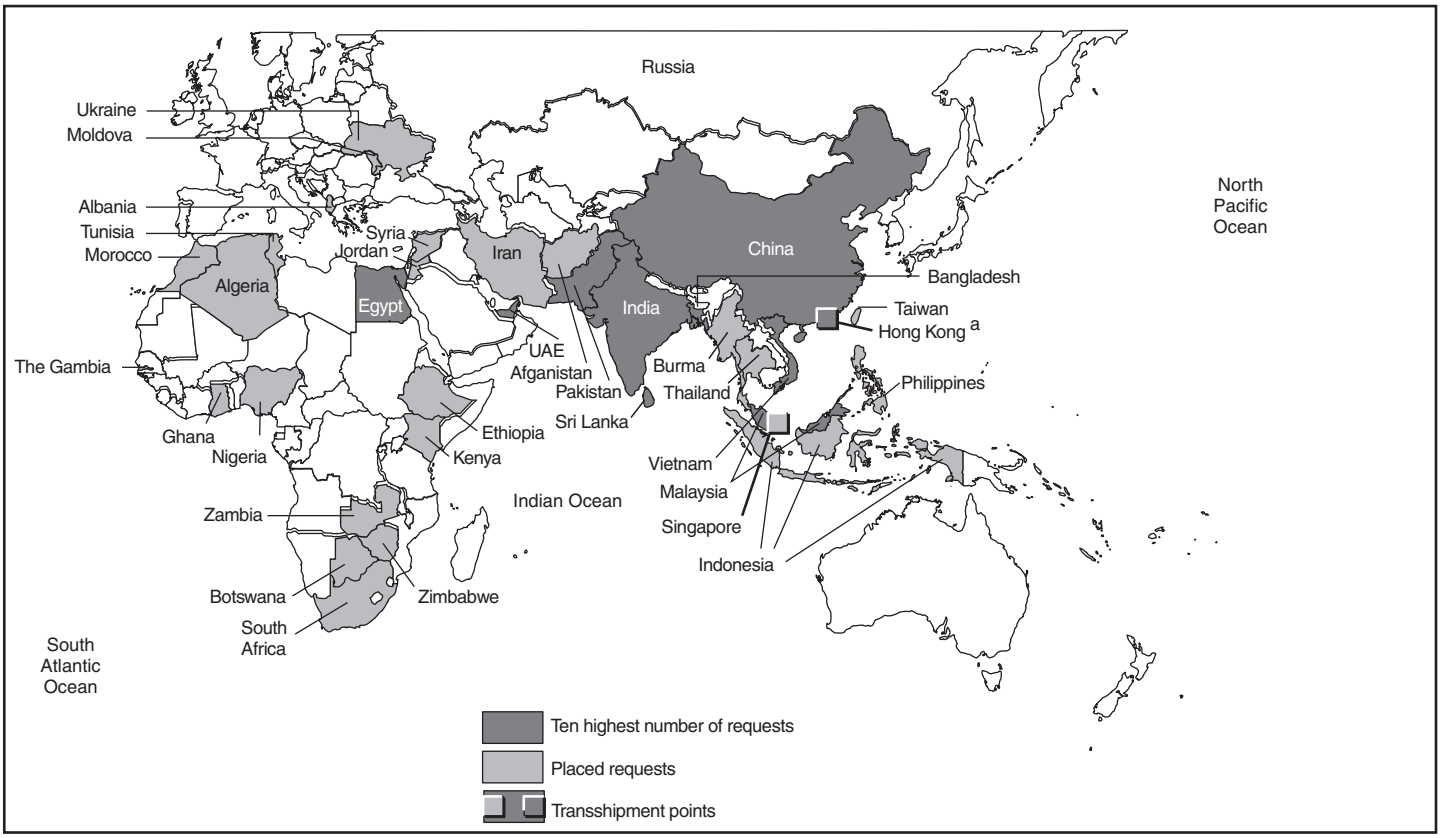
ELECTRONIC WASTE

EPA Needs to Better Control Harmful U.S. Exports through Stronger Enforcement and More Comprehensive Regulation



GAO-08-1044

Figure 2: Developing Countries Requesting CRTs on Two Internet E-commerce Web Sites, February 2008 to May 2008



Source: GAO analysis of two Internet-e-commerce sites.

[a]The information presented in figure 2 assumes that buyers do not post fictitious country names. It also assumes that there is no double counting of requests. Hong Kong is a special administrative region of China. Requests were also placed in Aruba, Peru, and Venezuela.

China and Hong Kong Define the Used Electronics Trade in Southeast Asia

China has received global attention over electronic waste export issues since 2002, when environmental groups exposed "egregious" electronics-recycling and disposal practices in the city of Guiyu and elsewhere in southeastern China. China's fast-growing economy drives the nation's demand for raw materials, and one way that this demand is met is by importing used electronic products, according to a 2005 report by the

Figure 5: Broken CRT Monitors from an Illegal Shipment of Used CRTs



Source: GAO.

We received photographic evidence showing that this illegal shipment of CRT monitors originated from the Denver metropolitan area. According to a third-party source, these monitors came from an electronics recycler in Colorado, which claims to hold 20 to 30 community recycling events each year for homeowners' associations, city governments, and property managers. The company's Web site also states that "many domestic recycling companies ship e-waste to China, where it ends up harming the environment and the population. With [this company], your e-waste is recycled properly, right here in the United States, not simply dumped on somebody else."